

POCO C65

All style, little substance

The budget smartphone segment in India necessitates an aggressive approach owing to the overwhelming number of options available. POCO, undeterred by the mere 10-month interval since introducing the budget-friendly POCO C55 in India, has swiftly returned to the fray with yet another economical C-series offering in the market – the POCO C65. This successor to the C55 boasts some notable upgrades including a slimmer body, improved display refresh rate, upgraded storage, and faster charging. Would I prefer it if POCO had added 5G to the mix by ditching some of these features? Yes, but we can't have it all. Let's see what POCO's latest budget smartphone offers and how it stacks up against its competitors.

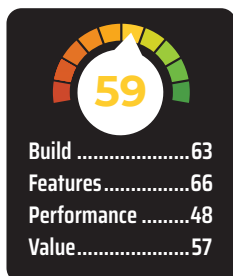
BUILD AND DESIGN

The POCO C65 is chic and simplistically designed. At just 8.1 mm thick, the phone has shed a solid 0.7 mm in comparison to its predecessor, giving it a streamlined appearance. The weight stays the same though, at 192 g. The unassuming rear panel has a mix of matte and glossy finishes. It is not a design that will immediately grab eyeballs, but once you notice the subtle nuances, you will appreciate the simplicity and class for the price.

The matte texture on the bottom of the rear panel doesn't attract fingerprints, however, the top area with the camera module is chock-full of fingerprints and smudges. There's a sizable POCO logo on the right side of the camera module while the left side features large circular rings that house the trifecta of cameras.

Once again, the frame has a matte finish and it does look super clean. Sadly, the ergonomics aren't the best

₹8,499



because the sharp, flat frame digs into your palm. I was disappointed by the quality of the buttons as well; the tactile response is quite subpar. There's a capacitive fingerprint sensor on the power button, and it worked decently

well during my testing. Overall, the POCO C65 has a classy design, but a few tweaks to improve the ergonomics could take it to the next level.

DISPLAY

The POCO C65 has a rather basic display with one notable improvement. The 6.74-inch IPS LCD display is marginally larger than its predecessor and now boasts 90 Hz refresh rate. The POCO C55 was limited to 60 Hz, so the faster refresh rate makes the phone feel noticeably smoother in operation. The display has an HD+ resolution, so things don't look super sharp.

Colours also look a tad faded and the viewing angles are mediocre. There's a teardrop-shaped notch as well that mars

immersiveness. The brightness is pretty decent in indoor settings – we got a tested maximum brightness of 353 nits, which is acceptable for the price. Display usability will take a hit under harsh sunlight though. There's Widevine L1 support for HD viewing of OTT content, but no HDR support.

The display is protected by Gorilla Glass 3 which should help safeguard the screen against accidental drops and scratches. The display also gets the TÜV Rheinland Low Blue Light certification and Flicker Free certification, which is nice to see at this price.

PERFORMANCE

The POCO C65 is not meant to be a power user's dream. The processor remains unchanged, it is equipped with the same MediaTek Helio G85 SoC that was present on its predecessor. The Helio G85 is a 4G processor, which raises the question – why wouldn't users just pay around ₹1-1.5K more and get themselves a perfectly capable 5G phone? The Lava Blaze 2 5G is one great option which gives you all the benefits of 5G under ₹10,000. Since the POCO C65 is situated in this price range, the lack of 5G is a huge con.

The MediaTek Helio G85 is also not the most powerful processor in this price segment. It is bested by the Lava Blaze 2 5G's Dimensity 6020 SoC in every single synthetic benchmark of note including AnTuTu, GeekBench, PCMark, and 3D Mark.

The real-world performance mimics this disparity in performance – the phone feels dated and sluggish, apps take forever to load, and the booting-up process is laboriously slow. Gaming is choppy and laggy as well, especially after 20-30 minutes of gameplay in BGMI or COD: Mobile.

As for the software, you get Android 13 with MIUI 14 out of the box. It is rife with bloatware; I'm talking about 9-10 preinstalled games alongside a bunch of random third-party apps. You get two years of software updates and three years of security updates, which is decent at the price. Sadly, the